MODULE 30 · DOMAIN 2 - PROCESS

Closing projects and phases

Closure criteria, formal acceptance, transition readiness, early termination, and closing finances, contracts, people and lessons.

DOMAIN II - Process EXAM WEIGHT 41% MODULE 30 of 49

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A project is finished when it is **accepted, handed over and learned from**. Not when the work stops.

Closing, step by step

01

Confirm criteria

Deliverables meet the agreed closure criteria.

02

Formal acceptance

Sponsor or customer signs off.

03

Transition

Operations or the next phase confirms it is ready.

04

Close out

Contracts, finances, resources, records.

05

Learn and celebrate

Final lessons, final report, recognition.

ON THE EXAM

Acceptance comes before release of people and closing of accounts. Order matters on the exam.

Closure criteria, agreed early

- The outline asks you to **determine criteria to successfully close** the project or phase.
- Set them at the start, in the charter and plan: what 'done' means for the whole project.
- Include deliverables accepted, transition complete, contracts closed, benefits handed to an owner.
- Without agreed criteria, closure becomes a negotiation, and often a dispute.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Agree how the project will close before it starts. Then closing is checking, not arguing.

Closing a phase or closing the project?

PHASE CLOSURE

A checkpoint

- End of a phase or stage
- Exit criteria reviewed at a gate
- Hand over to the next phase
- Decide: continue, change or stop

PROJECT CLOSURE

The end

- All work finished, or cancelled
- Final acceptance of the whole result
- Hand over to operations
- Everything closed and archived

THE TIEBREAKER

Phases close too, formally, with lessons and acceptance. A phase end is also a decision point.

Obtaining approval of completion

- The outline asks you to **obtain stakeholder approval of project completion**.
- Formal, written sign-off by the sponsor or customer, against the agreed criteria.
- If they will not sign, find out exactly which criterion they believe is unmet.
- New wishes at sign-off are new scope. They go through change control or a new project.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Acceptance is judged against the agreed criteria. New requests are welcome, but they are new work.

Validating readiness for transition

- The outline asks you to **validate readiness for transition**, to operations or the next phase.
- The receiving team is trained, has runbooks, support contacts and service levels.
- The receiving team **confirms** it is ready. Its word, not the project's, decides.
- A short period of extra support after go-live, sometimes called hypercare, smooths the handover.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Transition is ready when the receivers say so. Handing over to an unprepared team is not closure.

A transition readiness checklist

AREA	READY MEANS
People	Operations staff trained; support rotas in place
Documentation	Runbooks, known issues, configuration records handed over
Support	Service levels agreed; escalation contacts and suppliers named
Access and tools	Permissions, monitoring and licences transferred
Acceptance	Operations formally accepts responsibility

ON THE EXAM

Ask the receiving team to confirm each line. That confirmation is the readiness validation.

When a project is cancelled

- Cancelled projects still **close formally**.
- Document what was done, what was not, why it stopped, and what can be reused.
- Settle contracts under their termination clauses; close accounts; release people properly.
- Capture lessons: cancelled projects often teach the most.
- Simply stopping and walking away leaves costs, obligations and knowledge scattered.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Cancellation is not failure to close. Close a cancelled project as carefully as a completed one.

Final lessons learned and retrospective

- Hold a final, facilitated session with the team and key stakeholders, **before** people disperse.
- Blameless: what worked, what did not, what we would do differently.
- Move the lessons into the organisation's repository, as module 16 described.
- A survey sent after everyone has left gets few replies and fewer insights.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Capture final lessons while the team is still together. Then send them to the repository.

Closing contracts, finances and resources

- **Procurement**: verify deliverables accepted, settle claims, final payments, written notice (module 25).
- **Finances**: final invoices paid, accounts closed, unused reserves returned (module 26).
- **Resources**: people released with recognition and feedback; equipment returned; access removed (module 23).
- **Records**: archived, findable, and retained as policy requires.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Closing is thorough administration. Every contract, account, person and record ends properly.

The final report

- Performance against the **scope, schedule and cost baselines**, with explanations.
- **Quality** results and any known issues handed to operations.
- **Benefits**: what has been realised so far, what is expected, and who owns tracking them.
- Risks and issues transferred, and a summary of lessons learned.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The final report ends with benefits and their owner, because most benefits arrive after closure.

Closure on agile work

- Value is released continuously, so each **release** has its own small closure and review.
- The **product** often continues after the project; the team may continue too.
- Hand over the remaining backlog, the definition of done, and the product's operating knowledge.
- Stop when enough value is delivered, as module 20 described. That is a good close.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Agile work closes releases often, and closes the project when value, not the backlog, says so.

Recognise and celebrate

- Recognise the team's work publicly, and thank stakeholders who helped.
- Give individuals feedback their functional managers can use in appraisals.
- Mark the end. This is the adjourning stage of team development.
- People remember how a project ended. It shapes whether they want to work with you again.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Adjourning well is part of leading well. Recognition is a closing activity, not an optional extra.

Project Lantern: closing well

- Each clinic's go-live closed as a **phase**, with acceptance by the clinic manager and a short retrospective.
- Operations confirmed readiness line by line; the app team gave **four weeks of hypercare**.
- The kiosk contract closed with written notice after the last warranty claim was settled.
- The final report named the head of patient access as owner of the missed-appointment benefit.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Phases closed as they finished, operations confirmed readiness, contracts closed formally, benefits owned.

Scenario signals and the move

THE SCENARIO SAYS	THE MOVE
Customer wants a new feature before signing	Accept against criteria; new feature is new scope
Operations team not trained or ready	Validate readiness before handover
Project cancelled	Close it formally anyway
All deliverables complete; what first?	Confirm criteria and obtain formal acceptance
Team keen to leave before lessons	Short final retrospective before release
End of phase one of several	Close the phase formally at the gate

ON THE EXAM

Accept, transition, close out, learn. In that order, for phases and projects, finished or cancelled.

> A project has delivered everything in the scope baseline, and every acceptance criterion has been met and documented.
>
> At the final review, the customer says they will not sign off until an additional reporting feature is added.

What should the project manager do?

A. Add the feature at no charge to obtain the sign-off.

B. Close the project without the customer's sign-off.

C. Show that the agreed criteria are met, seek formal acceptance, and treat the feature as a change request or new work.

D. Refer the dispute to the legal department immediately.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Add it free.

Uncontrolled scope, and it teaches the customer that acceptance can be bargained.

B Close without sign-off.

Skips a required closure step and invites later disputes.

C Criteria met; seek acceptance; feature as new work.

Acceptance against what was agreed; the new wish handled properly.

D Go to legal.

Far too early. A conversation about the criteria comes first.

THE SIGNAL

Acceptance is judged against agreed criteria. A new wish at sign-off is new scope.

A new customer service platform is due to go live next week, when the project will hand it to the IT operations team.

The operations team says it has had no training, and no runbooks or support contacts have been provided.

What should the project manager do?

A Work with operations to agree readiness criteria, complete training and runbooks, and hand over only when they confirm readiness.

B Hand over as planned; operations will learn as they go.

C Keep the project team supporting the platform indefinitely.

D Close the project on schedule, since the platform works.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Agree criteria; train; hand over when confirmed.
Validates readiness for transition, with the receiving team deciding.

B Hand over anyway.
Operations learns by failing in front of customers.

C Project supports it forever.
The project never closes, and operations never takes ownership.

D Close on schedule.
A working platform nobody can support is not a successful handover.

THE SIGNAL

The receiving team is not ready: validate readiness before handover. Their confirmation decides.

> After a change in company strategy, the sponsor cancels a project that is sixty percent complete.
>
> Several team members have already been offered roles on other projects, and two supplier contracts are active.

What should the project manager do?

A Stop all work immediately and let the team move on.

B Continue until the work is finished, to avoid waste.

C Keep the team together in case a new project is approved.

D Close the project formally: document its status, settle the contracts, capture lessons, release people and archive.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Stop and walk away.

Leaves contracts open, costs running, and knowledge scattered.

B Finish anyway.

Overrides the sponsor's decision and spends on work no longer wanted.

C Hold the team together.

Holds people back from real roles for a project that may never exist.

D Formal closure.

Cancelled projects close properly too: status, contracts, lessons, people, records.

THE SIGNAL

A cancelled project is closed as carefully as a completed one.

> All deliverables on a predictive project are complete and have passed quality control. The team is ready to move on to other work.
>
> The project manager is planning the closing activities.

What should the project manager do first?

A Release the team members to their new assignments.

B Confirm the closure criteria are met and obtain formal acceptance from the customer.

C Archive the project documents.

D Hold the final lessons learned session.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do first?

A Release the team.

Too early. if acceptance reveals a gap, the people who can fix it are gone.

B Confirm criteria; formal acceptance.

The first closing step. Everything else depends on acceptance.

C Archive documents.

One of the last steps, after everything else is closed.

D Final lessons learned.

Important, but it follows acceptance and transition.

THE SIGNAL

'First' at closure: acceptance. Release people and archive only after it.

> At the end of an eighteen-month project, most team members are starting new roles next week. Some suggest skipping the final retrospective because 'everyone is busy'.
>
> The organisation has a lessons learned repository that is rarely updated.

What should the project manager do?

A Hold a short, facilitated final retrospective this week, and add the lessons to the repository.

B Skip the retrospective, since the team is busy.

C Send a survey after everyone has moved to their new roles.

D Write the lessons learned personally, without the team.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Short retrospective now; update the repository.

Captures eighteen months of learning while the people are still together.

B Skip it.

Loses the lessons the outline names as a closing activity.

C Survey later.

Few replies once people have moved on, and no discussion.

D PM writes them alone.

One view of eighteen months. The team's knowledge is missing.

THE SIGNAL

Capture final lessons before the team disperses, keep it short, and send it to the repository.

A three-phase infrastructure programme has finished its design phase. The construction phase is due to start next month.

The team is eager to begin construction immediately.

What should the project manager do?

A Start construction immediately to keep momentum.

B Close the whole programme and start a new one for construction.

C Leave closure activities until the end of the whole programme.

D Close the design phase formally: check exit criteria, obtain acceptance, capture lessons, and hand over at the gate.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Start construction now.

Skips the gate decision and the design's formal acceptance.

B Close the whole programme.

Confuses phase closure with project closure.

C Close everything at the end.

Loses the design phase's lessons and the gate decision.

D Formal phase closure at the gate.

Phases close too, and the gate decides whether to proceed.

THE SIGNAL

Each phase closes formally, at a gate that decides whether and how to continue.

Accept, transition, close out, learn. In that order.

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